NAME: _____ CLASS: _____ TEACHER: _____

KEY TOPIC 4 CHRONOLOGICAL ENQUIRY SEQUENCE • 1968–1975

Key Topic 4: The Escalation and Ending of the Conflict in Vietnam, 1968–75

Vietnamization, Domestic Opposition, Paris Peace Accords & The Fall of Saigon



HISTORICAL PRIMARY RECORD • 4 MAY 1970

National Guardsmen Facing Student Protesters at Kent State, 4 May 1970

Ohio National Guardsmen deploy on the university commons with rifles during anti-war demonstrations against the secret invasion of Cambodia, moments before four students were fatally shot.

PEARSON EDEXCEL OPTION 33 • KEY TOPIC 4 CONTENT OFFICIAL SPECIFICATION DIRECTORY

1 Opposition to the War

- Reasons for the growth of opposition, including the student movement, TV and media coverage of the war and the draft system.
- Public reaction to the My Lai Massacre (1968). The trial of Lt. Calley.
- The Kent State University shootings (1970).

2 Support for the War

- Reasons for support for the war, including the fear of communism.
- The 'hard hats' and the 'silent majority'.

3 The Peace Process and End of the War

- Reasons for, and key features of, the peace negotiations (1972–73).
- The significance of the **Paris Peace Agreement (1973)**.
- The economic and human costs of the war for the USA.

4 Reasons for the Failure of the Usa in Vietnam

- The strengths of North Vietnam, including the significance of Russian and Chinese support, Vietcong tactics and the Ho Chi Minh Trail.
- The weaknesses of the US armed forces. The failure of US tactics.
- The impact of opposition to the war in the USA.

LIVING TIMELINE • PART 1: CHRONOLOGICAL ANCHORS (KEY TOPIC 4)

Instructions: As you study each enquiry lesson, complete the timeline missions by sketching and annotating in the corresponding dual-coding sketchpads below.

12 November 1969 • My Lai Massacre Exposed to the Public

MORAL CRISIS

Journalist Seymour Hersh reveals that US soldiers murdered over 500 unarmed Vietnamese civilians in the hamlet of Son My in March 1968, sparking nationwide revulsion.

3 November 1969 • Nixon's "Silent Majority" Address

DOMESTIC POLARIZATION

President Nixon appeals to conservative, patriotic Americans to support his Vietnamization policy against the demands of vocal campus anti-war protesters.

30 April 1970 • US Incursion into Cambodia Announced

EXPANSION OF WAR

Nixon announces the secret invasion of neutral Cambodia to destroy communist sanctuaries along the Ho Chi Minh Trail, sparking riots across hundreds of college campuses.

LIVING TIMELINE • PART 2: CHRONOLOGICAL ANCHORS (KEY TOPIC 4)

Instructions: Complete the dual-coding sketches to permanently anchor these chronological turning points in long-term memory.

4 May 1970 • Kent State University Shootings

DOMESTIC TRAGEDY

Ohio National Guardsmen fire 67 rounds into unarmed student demonstrators protesting the Cambodian invasion, killing four students and triggering a nationwide student strike of four million.

27 January 1973 • Paris Peace Accords Signed

AMERICAN EXIT

The United States, North Vietnam, South Vietnam, and the PRG sign the ceasefire agreement in Paris, securing the complete withdrawal of all US military personnel and POW releases.

30 April 1975 • Fall of Saigon to Communist Forces

COMMUNIST VICTORY

North Vietnamese tanks smash through the gates of the Presidential Palace in Saigon. The remaining Americans are evacuated by helicopter from the embassy rooftop; Vietnam is reunited.

Why did so many Americans oppose the Vietnam War (like at My Lai and Kent State)?

AUDIO • QUIZ

1 • How did uncensored nightly television coverage turn American domestic public opinion against the Vietnam Wa...

- First 'living room war'
- Uncensored colour news footage
- Nightly body count reports

2 • Why did class and racial inequalities in the military draft provoke widespread campus resistance and draft car...

- Selective Service draft lottery
- College deferment bias
- Draft card public burning

3 • How did revelations of the My Lai massacre undermine the moral justification for the American war effort?

- My Lai massacre (March 1968)
- Lieutenant William Calley
- 500 civilian deaths exposed

4 • Why did the shooting of student protesters at Kent State University in May 1970 cause nationwide campus uphe...

- Cambodian incursion protests
- Kent State shootings (1970)
- Four students killed

5 • How did the publication of the Pentagon Papers permanently damage public trust in presidential honesty?

- Daniel Ellsberg whistleblower
- New York Times publication
- Government deceit revealed

"My Lai Massacre (March 1968): Charlie Company murdered over 500 unarmed Vietnamese civilians; exposed to the public in late 1969."

Question 2: Explain Why [12 marks • 15 mins] EDEXCEL PAPER 3

Score: [/ 12]

Explain why public opposition to the Vietnam War intensified in the United States between 1968 and 1971. [12 marks]

You may use in your answer:
- Revelations of the My Lai massacre (November 1969)
- The Kent State University shootings (May 1970)

(You must also use information of your own.)

ANALYTICAL CONNECTIVES: *One decisive reason was that... • For example, this meant that... • This directly triggered... • Therefore, this was critical because... • On the other hand, another factor was... • Consequently, the ultimate result was...*

Write your response in the space provided below:

(Response continues on Page 6)

TIMELINE MISSION Turn to Pages 2–3 (Key Topic 4.1). In the drawing box, sketch the peace sign and a draft-card burning on a college campus alongside the Kent State memorial. [ ] Done

QUESTION 1 PRACTICE **INFERENCE FROM SOURCE A** **4 MARKS • 5 MINS** **Score: [/ 4]**

Give two things you can infer from Source A about the introduction of the military draft lottery in 1969. [4 marks]

SOURCE A *Peers Commission Inquiry into the My Lai Massacre, Department of the Army (1970)*
Contemporary archival extract.

(i) What I can infer: *[1 mark]*

Details in SOURCE A that tell me this: *[1 mark]*

(ii) What I can infer: *[1 mark]*

Details in SOURCE A that tell me this: *[1 mark]*

Why did some Americans support the Vietnam War and the 'Silent Majority'?

AUDIO • QUIZ

1 • Why did millions of patriotic Americans continue to view the Vietnam War as an essential Cold War struggle?

- Cold War anti-communist consensus
- Support for US troops
- Fear of global surrender

2 • How did President Nixon's 'Silent Majority' speech mobilize conservative support for his administration's war p...

- 'Silent Majority' speech (1969)
- Appeal to conservative voters
- Counter-protest mobilization

3 • What did the May 1970 'Hard Hat Riots' in Manhattan reveal about working-class hostility toward student anti-...

- Wall Street construction workers
- 'Hard Hat Riots' (1970)
- Assault on student protesters

4 • Why did congressional hawks argue that immediate American withdrawal would catastrophically damage US g...

- Congressional hawk faction
- Defending American honor
- Commitment to SEATO allies

5 • How did Nixon's massive 1972 electoral victory prove the enduring strength of the conservative 'Silent Majority'?

- 1972 Presidential Election
- 49-state Nixon landslide
- Defeat of anti-war McGovern

Question 2: Explain Why [12 marks • 15 mins] EDEXCEL PAPER 3

Score: [/ 12]

Explain why President Richard Nixon introduced the policy of 'Vietnamization' in 1969. [12 marks]

You may use in your answer: • Domestic anti-war protests and the 'Silent Majority' • The aim of achieving 'peace with honour' ***(You must also use information of your own.)***

ANALYTICAL CONNECTIVES: *One decisive reason was that... • For example, this meant that... • This directly triggered... • Therefore, this was critical because... • On the other hand, another factor was... • Consequently, the ultimate result was...*

Write your response in the space provided below:

(Response continues on Page 9)

TIMELINE MISSION Turn to Pages 2–3 (Key Topic 4.2). In the drawing box, sketch President Nixon delivering his "Silent Majority" speech flanked by construction workers waving American flags. [ ] Done

"Kent State Shootings (4 May 1970): Ohio National Guardsmen fired 67 rounds into unarmed student protesters, killing four."

QUESTION 2 CONTINUATION: QUESTION 2 *(Conclude your causal analysis with sustained historical links)*

QUESTION 1 PRACTICE **INFERENCE FROM SOURCE A** **4 MARKS • 5 MINS** **Score: [/ 4]**

Give two things you can infer from Source A about President Nixon's televised 'Silent Majority' address (November 1969). [4 marks]

SOURCE A *President Richard Nixon, Address to the Nation on the War in Vietnam (3 November 1969)*

Let historians not record that when America was the most powerful nation in the world we passed on the other side of the road and allowed the last hopes for peace and freedom of millions of people to be suffocated b...

(i) What I can infer: *[1 mark]*

Details in SOURCE A that tell me this: *[1 mark]*

(ii) What I can infer: *[1 mark]*

Details in SOURCE A that tell me this: *[1 mark]*

How did the US exit Vietnam, and why did South Vietnam fall so quickly in 1975?

AUDIO • QUIZ

1 • Why was Henry Kissinger's concession allowing North Vietnamese troops to remain in South Vietnam so contro...

- Henry Kissinger & Le Duc Tho
- Secret Paris peace talks
- PAVN troops permitted South

2 • What did Nixon intend to achieve by unleashing the massive Operation Linebacker II 'Christmas Bombings' in ...

- Operation Linebacker II
- B-52 'Christmas Bombings'
- Hanoi & Haiphong battered

3 • What were the primary terms of the 1973 Paris Peace Accords, and how did they favor North Vietnam strategical...

- 1973 Paris Peace Accords
- Complete US military withdrawal
- American POWs repatriated

4 • How did the final departure of US combat troops in March 1973 leave South Vietnam militarily vulnerable?

- Final US combat troops depart
- Military Assistance Command closes
- ARVN left vulnerable

5 • Why was the 1973 War Powers Act passed by Congress, and how did it prevent future US military intervention?

- 1973 War Powers Act
- Nixon veto overridden
- Presidential 60-day limit

"Pentagon Papers (1971): Leaked top-secret DoD documents revealed four successive presidents had lied to Congress about Vietnam."

Question 2: Explain Why [12 marks • 15 mins] EDEXCEL PAPER 3

Score: [/ 12]

Explain why the Paris Peace Accords were signed in January 1973. [12 marks]

You may use in your answer:
- The 'Christmas Bombings' (Operation Linebacker II, December 1972)
- The diplomatic rapprochement between the US, China, and the Soviet Union

(You must also use information of your own.)

ANALYTICAL CONNECTIVES: *One decisive reason was that... • For example, this meant that... • This directly triggered... • Therefore, this was critical because... • On the other hand, another factor was... • Consequently, the ultimate result was...*

Write your response in the space provided below:

(Response continues on Page 12)

TIMELINE MISSION Turn to Pages 2–3 (Key Topic 4.3). In the drawing box, sketch the signing table at the Paris Peace Accords alongside American POWs stepping off the plane at Operation Homecoming. [ ] Done

QUESTION 1 PRACTICE **INFERENCE FROM SOURCE A** **4 MARKS • 5 MINS** **Score: [/ 4]**

Give two things you can infer from Source A about the signing of the Paris Peace Accords in January 1973. [4 marks]

SOURCE A *Associated Press Wirephoto / United States Department of State Archives*

Contemporary archival extract.

(i) What I can infer: *[1 mark]*

Details in SOURCE A that tell me this: *[1 mark]*

(ii) What I can infer: *[1 mark]*

Details in SOURCE A that tell me this: *[1 mark]*

What were the main reasons why the US failed to win the war in Vietnam?

AUDIO • QUIZ

1 • Why did the South Vietnamese military collapse so rapidly during the communist Spring Offensive of 1975?

- 1975 Spring Offensive
- Central Highlands collapse
- ARVN panic & retreat

2 • How did the frantic helicopter evacuations and the fall of Saigon on 30 April 1975 symbolize total American defe...

- Operation Frequent Wind
- Helicopter embassy evacuations
- Fall of Saigon (30 April)

3 • Why was the ideological commitment of Vietnamese communists superior to the fragile political legitimacy of S...

- Vietnamese nationalist resolve
- Saigon government corruption
- Asymmetric political will

4 • Why were advanced American military technology and firepower unable to overcome asymmetric jungle guerri...

- Inappropriate conventional firepower
- Hearts and minds alienated
- Jungle terrain resilience

5 • How did the loss of American domestic political will ultimately decide the outcome of the Vietnam War?

- Loss of domestic support
- Watergate political paralysis
- Congress cuts military aid

"Paris Peace Accords (Jan 1973): Ceasefire signed; complete withdrawal of all US combat personnel; return of American POWs."

Question 2: Explain Why [12 marks • 15 mins] EDEXCEL PAPER 3

Score: [/ 12]

Explain why South Vietnam collapsed so rapidly in 1975 following the withdrawal of US forces. [12 marks]

You may use in your answer:
- The corruption and military weaknesses of the ARVN
- US congressional cuts to military and economic aid

(You must also use information of your own.)

ANALYTICAL CONNECTIVES: *One decisive reason was that... • For example, this meant that... • This directly triggered... • Therefore, this was critical because... • On the other hand, another factor was... • Consequently, the ultimate result was...*

Write your response in the space provided below:

(Response continues on Page 15)

TIMELINE MISSION Turn to Pages 2–3 (Key Topic 4.4). In the drawing box, sketch an overloaded Huey helicopter evacuating personnel from the US Embassy rooftop during the Fall of Saigon. [ ] Done

"War Powers Act (1973): Congress passed legislation restricting presidential authority to commit US military forces overseas."

QUESTION 2 CONTINUATION: QUESTION 2 *(Conclude your causal analysis with sustained historical links)*

QUESTION 1 PRACTICE **INFERENCE FROM SOURCE A** **4 MARKS • 5 MINS** **Score: [/ 4]**

Give two things you can infer from Source A about the physical and psychological toll on US combat soldiers in Vietnam. [4 marks]

SOURCE A *National Archives Still Pictures, Record Group 111, Washington D.C.*
Contemporary archival extract.

(i) What I can infer: *[1 mark]*

Details in SOURCE A that tell me this: *[1 mark]*

(ii) What I can infer: *[1 mark]*

Details in SOURCE A that tell me this: *[1 mark]*

Question 3(a): Source Utility [8 marks • 12 mins]

Study Sources B and C. How useful are Sources B and C for an enquiry into the main reason for the growth of opposition to the Vietnam War in the USA (1968–71)?

Target: AO3 [8 marks]: Analyse sources on Content, Contextual Knowledge, and Provenance (Nature, Origin, Purpose).

SOURCE B — Primary Evidence

"It seems now more certain than ever that the bloody experience of Vietnam is to end in a stalemate. To say that we are closer to victory today is to believe, in the face of the evidence, the optimists who have been wrong in the past. To suggest we are on the edge of defeat is to yield to unreasonable despair. To say that we are mired in stalemate seems the only realistic, yet unsatisfactory, conclusion. It is increasingly clear to this reporter that the only rational way out will be to negotiate, not as victors, but as an honorable people who lived up to their pledge to defend democracy and did the best they could."

Provenance: Broadcast to millions of American households by the nation's most respected news anchor following his fact-finding mission to Vietnam after the Tet Offensive.

SOURCE C — Primary Evidence

"Rich young men with political connections go to prestigious colleges and receive student deferments. Working-class and Black youth who cannot afford university are handed M16 rifles and shipped off to die in the jungles for a corrupt dictatorship in Saigon. Over 35,000 American boys have already come home in aluminum coffins, while Washington politicians lie about 'progress'. We refuse to participate in the slaughter of Vietnamese peasants. Burn your draft cards! Join the nationwide Moratorium on October 15! Strike against the war machine!"

Provenance: Protest pamphlet produced and circulated by the student anti-war organization Students for a Democratic Society (SDS) prior to the October 1969 Moratorium.

SOURCE B UTILITY (CONTENT & COP): ILLUSTRATES THE IMMENSE INFLUENCE OF TELEVISED NEWS JOURNALISM; CRONKITE DECLARING THE WAR A STALEMATE DESTROYED THE "CREDIBILITY GAP" AND SWAYED MIDDLE-CLASS OPINION. *(Analyse Content, Historical Context & Provenance NOP)*

SOURCE C UTILITY (CONTENT & COP): ILLUSTRATES THE ANGER OVER THE MILITARY DRAFT SYSTEM, CLASS INEQUALITIES (DEFERMENTS FOR RICH STUDENTS), RISING BODY BAGS, AND THE DIRECT ACTION TACTICS OF STUDENT GROUPS LIKE SDS. **Score: [/ 8]**

HISTORICAL INTERPRETATIONS 1 & 2

Study Interpretations 1 and 2 below for Questions 3(b), 3(c), and 3(d)

INTERPRETATION 1

"The fundamental engine driving mass opposition to the war was television journalism and the uncensored visual exposure of combat horrors. Vietnam was America's first 'living-room war'. Night after night, millions of ordinary Americans watched unedited color footage of wounded soldiers, burning huts, civilian body counts, and napalmed children alongside their evening dinners. When trusted national figures like Walter Cronkite declared the war unwinnable after the Tet Offensive, it shattered the government's credibility. The media's subsequent exposure of atrocities like the My Lai massacre in 1969 made it impossible for the moral conscience of middle America to support the war any longer."

Historian Chester Pach, 'The Real Media War on Vietnam' (1996)

INTERPRETATION 2

"While television coverage was vivid, the primary catalyst for mass domestic opposition was the personal, immediate threat posed by the military draft system combined with skyrocketing American casualties. Young men faced the terrifying prospect of conscription into an ambiguous conflict, producing a massive student rebellion across college campuses. Student organizations like SDS, energized by civil rights techniques, transformed anti-war sentiment into sustained street mobilization, draft-card burnings, and nationwide moratoriums involving millions of demonstrators. It was the visceral fear of the draft, coupled with the rising toll of over 50,000 American deaths, that galvanized grassroots resistance and made the war politically unsustainable."

Historian Melvin Small, 'Antiwarriors: The Vietnam War and the Battle for America's Hearts and Minds' (2002)

Question 3(b): Main Difference in Views [4 marks • 5 mins]

Score: [/ 4]

Study Interpretations 1 and 2. They give different views about the main reason for the growth of opposition to the Vietnam War. What is the main difference between these views? Explain your answer, using details from both interpretations.

Formula: Interpretation 1 argues that anti-war opposition was primarily generated by uncensored television media coverage and news anchors like Walter Cronkite exposing combat horrors and atrocities (My Lai), whereas Interpretation 2 argues that opposition was driven primarily by the personal threat of the military draft, rising casualties, and campus student protests.

Question 3(c): Reason Why Interpretations Differ [4 marks • 5 mins]

Score: [/ 4]

Suggest one reason why Interpretations 1 and 2 give different views about the main reason for the growth of opposition to the Vietnam War. You may use Sources B and C to help explain your answer.

Examiner Guidance: The historians hold different views because they have examined different sources of evidence. The author of Interpretation 1 has focused on television broadcast history and media journalism such as Source B, showing how Cronkite's commentary swayed middle America. In contrast, the author of Interpretation 2 has focused on youth resistance records and protest flyers such as Source C, emphasizing the direct fear of the draft, casualty rates, and student activism on university campuses.

QUESTION 3(D) ESSAY PLANNING & CRITERIA SETUP

16 Marks + 4 SPaG = 20 Marks • 25 Mins

How far do you agree with Interpretation 2 about the main reason for the growth of opposition to the Vietnam War in the USA (1968–71)?

Thesis Prompt: Establish your judgment criteria, select quotes from Interpretations 1 & 2, and deploy contextual historical knowledge.

Criteria Planning Canvas: Establish criteria benchmark, map quotes from Int 1 & Int 2, and outline your verdict: *(Essay continues on Page 19)*

Level 4 Target (13–16 Marks): Balanced analysis of both views • Sustained contextual knowledge • Justified criteria-led judgment. **SPaG: 4/4 MARKS**

"Human & Financial Toll: Over 58,000 American soldiers dead; over 2 million Vietnamese dead; $168 billion spent."

Question 3(d): Evaluative Essay on Historical Interpretations

AO4: [/ 16] | SPaG: [/ 4] | Total: [/ 20]

[16 MARKS + 4 SPAG = 20 MARKS • TIMED ESSAY: 25 MINS]

How far do you agree with Interpretation 2 about the main reason for the growth of opposition to the Vietnam War in the USA (1968–71)?

Write your response in the space provided below:

Band 4 Criteria Check:	[ ] Criteria Established	[ ] Both Ints Explored	[ ] Precise Own Knowledge	[ ] Justified Verdict	**Teacher Sign-off:** _____

STUDENT ASSESSMENT RECORD • KEY TOPIC 4 TRACKER

Paper 3: Conflict at Home and Abroad: the USA, 1954–1975 (The Escalation and Ending of the Conflict in Vietnam, 1968–75)

PUPIL: _____ **TARGET GRADE:** ☐ **PREDICTED:** ☐ **ATTITUDE:** 1 • 2 • 3 • 4 • 5

#	ENQUIRY / ASSESSMENT UNIT	DO NOW (10M)	Q1 INFER (4M)	Q2 EXPLAIN (12M)	MODULE TOTAL
1	**KT4.1: Why did so many Americans oppose the Vietnam War (like at My Lai and Kent State)?** *"Why did so many Americans oppose the Vietnam War (like at My Lai and Kent State)?"*	/ 10	/ 4	/ 12	/ 26
2	**KT4.2: Why did some Americans support the Vietnam War and the 'Silent Majority'?** *"Why did some Americans support the Vietnam War and the 'Silent Majority'?"*	/ 10	/ 4	/ 12	/ 26
3	**KT4.3: How did the US exit Vietnam, and why did South Vietnam fall so quickly in 1975?** *"How did the US exit Vietnam, and why did South Vietnam fall so quickly in 1975?"*	/ 10	/ 4	/ 12	/ 26
4	**KT4.4: What were the main reasons why the US failed to win the war in Vietnam?** *"What were the main reasons why the US failed to win the war in Vietnam?"*	/ 10	/ 4	/ 12	/ 26
★	**Section B Capstone Assessment (pp. 16–19)** *Q3(a) Utility [8m] • Q3(b) Study Views [4m] • Q3(c) Why Differ [4m] • Q3(d) Evaluative Essay [20m]*	Q3(a): / 8	Q3(b): / 4	Q3(c): / 4 • Q3(d): / 20	/ 36
KEY TOPIC 4 CUMULATIVE ASSESSMENT TOTALS		**Do Now: / 40**	**Q1 Infer: / 16**	**Q2 Cause: / 48**	**/ 140**

TEACHER FORMATIVE ASSESSMENT • WWW / EBI FEEDBACK

WHAT WENT WELL (WWW):

_____

_____

_____

EVEN BETTER IF (EBI):

_____

_____

_____

Teacher Signature: _____ **Date:** _____

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KT 4.1	KT 4.2	KT 4.3	KT 4.4
SCAN TO QUIZ	SCAN TO QUIZ	SCAN TO QUIZ	SCAN TO QUIZ
Score: / 20	**Score: / 20**	**Score: / 20**	**Score: / 20**

"Question 3(c): Historians evaluate differing evidence pools: uncensored broadcast journalism vs anti-war SDS activism."